

Mata o Muna 1

Te Fenua ko Nanumea

A Nanumea ni iloa ake mai ona tala mua, me he fenua ni tū tokotahi ake ailoa ia te ia mai tona kāmātāga, ke oko ki te taimi ni noho i ai mai lalo i te pūlega a Egelani, telā e kau i ai a te Tuvalu katoa, pēla hoki mo fenua o Kilipati ki mātū o Tuvalu. A Nanumea ni noho hoki ailoa ia te ia mo ana pulepulega faka aliki; kae mai te tai 'pau o 'gana mo faifaiga a fenua konei e iva o te atu fenua o Tuvalu, ni iloa ake i ai mai ona tala mua me i loto i te fia o senetenali, e i ai ailoa ni fehokotakiga ni mafai o maua e lātou, mai te faimā'laga o lātou mai te fenua ki te fenua. A fenua konei ki mātū, Nanumaga mo Niutao kolā e tai pili ki Nanumea, pelā me lahi a te taimi fehokotaki o lāua ki Nanumea, i lō fenua o te Tuvalu ki saute mo te hopogālā. E foliki a te fehokotakiga i pō mua. A fenua takitahi o te Tuvalu e tahi tū tokotahi ailoa ia te ia, ka hē kaufakatahi hoki pelā me he Atufenua e tahi.

Nanumea mo tana Lalolagi i Pō Mua

Koa pēhea nei a te leva o te māfua akega o te fenua tenei ko Nanumea? E hē ai ailoa he auala e mafai ai o iloa tonu a te mea tenei, ka e mafai e tātou o tuku faka'tau a te taimi mai te fakaogaga o auala kehekehe. Mai te fakaaogā e tātou a mau a tagata mahala (saienitisi), koa mafai i ai o iloa e tātou me i tino mua o te kau Polenisia ni faimā'laga ki te Pasefika mai sautehaegālā o Asia ki te 5000 tauhaga koa olo atu. A lātou konei e tā'vili ki 'gana kolā e tai holo'pau mo 'gana a fenua Polenisia o pō nei, olo tele ailoa a lātou konei pēnā i afe o tauhaga i loto i fenua o te Melanisia, pelā mo New Britain mo New Ireland, fakamuli ifo ko Vanuatu, oko atu hoki ailoa ki Fiji, telā ko te 3200 tauhaga koa fano. (Koa noho i ai pelā ki te 1200 B.C.). I te taimi tenei koa i ai ni tino i Tonga mo Samoa, e pelā hoki i ai i Fiji. Konei Atufenua e tolu ni fai momea tonu, te gāloto, ni fakavae mai i ai a faifaiga a tino o fenua kolā e 'taku pelā me ni Polenisia. A faifaiga mo te 'gana a Tuvalu pelā me tai p'pau mo fenua Polenisia ki te Togālā (kae pelā me hē hepaki tonu mo faiga a fenua Polenisia ki te haegālā pelā mo te Cook Islands, Tahiti, Marquesas, Hawaii mo New Zealand/Aotearoa.)

I te mea ko te foliki o te hukehukega o tino mahala ki mea taumua ("archaeological work") i loto i te Tuvalu, telā lā koa hē mafai o fakatino tonu te taimi tonu ni oko mai i ai a 'tou tino mua ki Tuvalu. E i ai he fakamatalaga e fai pelā me i motu mo fenua maulalo o Tuvalu e hē 'tau o nohogina e tino (me hē

Chapter 1

The Island of Nanumea

Nanumea has been an independent political unit for most of its history. From its founding, up to the time when Britain created a protectorate including Tuvalu with the islands of Kiribati to the north, Nanumea stood alone as a self-governing chieftainship. We know from traditional tales and from similarities in language and culture that the nine islands of Te Atu Tuvalu were in communication with each other for centuries through occasional voyages and visits. The northern islands of Nanumaga and Niutao, which are closest to Nanumea, seem to have been in more regular contact with Nanumea than were the Tuvalu islands further to the south and east. Contacts were not frequent, and each Tuvalu island was an independent place, not united into a "country."

The Nanumean World in Ancient Times

How long has Nanumea existed as a society? We have no way to be absolutely certain about this, although we can arrive at a rough estimate through several different avenues. Using evidence from scientific sources, we know that the ancestors of the present-day Polynesians voyaged into the Pacific from southeast Asia up to 5000 years ago. These people, speaking languages related to present-day Polynesian languages, moved gradually over several thousand years through the Melanesian island groups such as New Britain and New Ireland, and later Vanuatu, reaching Fiji at least 3,200 years ago (this would be at least 1,200 B.C.) Tonga and Samoa were settled after this, and together with Fiji, these three island groups were the core cultural area from which all the islands in what is called Polynesia were settled. Tuvalu has close cultural and linguistic connections to this western group of Polynesian cultures (and more distant links to eastern Polynesian cultures such as Cook Islands, Tahiti, Marquesas, Hawaii and New Zealand).

Because there has been little archaeological work in Tuvalu, it is not possible yet to use this type of scientific work to date our ancestors' arrival in Tuvalu. One study says that the low atolls and islands of Tuvalu were not inhabitable by people (because they were not high enough above sea

'hae mālosi ki luga mo te kilikili tai) mai mua o te tauhaga heai (0 A.D., ulā i te taimi o Iesu Keliso). Kae fai e tonu a te mea tenei, a te Tuvalu mo Nanumea ka hē 'tau o nohogina e tino mai mua o te taimi tenā. Telā lā koa mafai nei o i ai he mafauauga ki te taimi ni oko muamua i ai a tino ki Nanumea. I te pulapula atu ki tuhituhiga e uiga ki mea taumua faka Polenisia, koa mafai i ai e tātou o fakatautau atu me ia Nanumea mo Tuvalu ni nohogina e tino pelā me i te vā o te tauhaga 'heai' (telā ko te 2000 tauhaga koa olo), kae moi fai pelā me ko te fakaotiotiga ko te 1000 me ko te 1200 A.D.

E fakatau me e māhāni tele o oko mai a vaka e uke o noho i luga i Tuvalu, kae hē tahi me lua. Kae pelā mo te mea e lavea atu a te moe fakaloaloa o te tui fenua mai mātū-saute telā e kau i ai a Tuvalu mo fenua o Kilipati, e tino mai pelā me he auala fai malagagina e te tokoukega o tino i vā o taimi. E i ai ni tino e faimā'laga pili ailoa ki uta mo te fenua, kae koa i ai ni tino koa mafai o 'noho ake ki uta i te fenua. A te Tuvalu he Atufenua e tahi ni nohogina e ia a motu ake fō'liki o fenua o te Melanisia mo te Maikolonisia (penei mo motu Polenisia konei: Tikopia, Anuta, West Futuna, Sikaiana, Bellona, Rennell, Ontong Java, Takuu, Nukuoro, Nukumanu mo fenua ake hoki).

Pelā ailoa mo te 'tu 'mao mo te foliki o te tulaga faimā'laga ki fenua tai 'mao atu o te Tuvalu, a tino Nanumea ni mailoga hoki ailoa a te 'heke o ana faifaiga faka'pau ki faifaiga e uke faka lenisia. E i ai hoki he tai 'heke o tona 'gana mai fenua ake o te Tuvalu, mai ana muna pelā hoki a te gaugāleo, kae hē motuhia a tino Tuvalu mai fenua ake o te atu fenua e māina ailoa, pelā hoki mo tino Nanumea e māina ailoa i olotou 'gana.

Faitega o te Lalolagi o Nanumea

I feitu katoa o te lalolagi, e tofua ailoa a fenua mo olotou tala mua mo tala e uiga ki te lalolagi, kolā e fakamatala mai i ai a te fakavaemaiga o te lalolagi mo atua, tātata, manu mo te feitu tāua hoki e tahi telā ko te mate. E mafai o fai a tala konei me ni tala tonu kae tapu. A tino Nanumea mua, kae koi tu tokotahi i ai a ia, i te taimi ka hēai ni fehokotakiga mo tino Eulopa, e hē motuhia koi mauluga 'ki a te tulaga tau talitonuga fakalātou ailoa. Kae tai fakautu i te ukega o mahala mua faka te fenua koa lahi nei ki te 'galo.

He ā nei a te iloa o tātou e uiga ki lotu mo talitonuga o tino Nanumea mua? Koa iloa e tātou me ko Nanumea mo Tuvalu he vaega e kau i loto i faifaiga faka Polenisia, telā lā koa iloa i ai e tātou me i o'tou tupuga mua ni 'kaufakatahi mo tino Polenisia ake o

level) before about the year zero (about the time of Christ). If this is accurate, Tuvalu and Nanumea could not have been settled before this time, so this gives a useful "earliest possible" date for Nanumean settlement. Given the general settlement history of other Polynesian places, we can estimate that Nanumea and Tuvalu might have been settled as early as around the year zero (some 2000 years ago), though perhaps as late of 1000 or 1,200 AD.

Many canoe voyages probably brought settlers to live in Tuvalu, not just a single voyage or two. It also seems likely that the north-south chain of atolls making up Tuvalu and the islands of the Gilberts were a sort of voyaging "channel," visited by many groups of people over time. Some voyagers may have just passed nearby, while others probably stayed to settle down. Tuvalu seems to have been one of the places from which further settlement of many islands in Melanesia and Micronesia took place (these "Polynesian Outliers" include Tikopia, Anuta, West Futuna, Sikaiana, Bellona, Rennell, Ontong Java, Takuu, Nukuoro, Nukumanu, and others).

As a relatively isolated community with little regular voyaging to the further islands of Tuvalu, ancient Nanumea developed its own unique version of the wider Polynesian cultural tradition. It also developed a dialect of the Tuvalu language with distinctive vocabulary and intonation patterns, although Tuvaluans from the other islands of the archipelago could understand this dialect, just as Nanumeans could understand theirs.

Creation of the Nanumean World

Societies in every part of the world developed mythological or cosmological stories to explain the origins of the world and gods, people, animals, as well as important features such as death. These stories were considered to be true, and were held to be sacred. In ancient Nanumea, that is, the society of Nanumea as it existed independently and before contact with foreigners from Europe, there were undoubtedly a wealth of these religious traditions. Unfortunately, most of this sophisticated ancient knowledge has been lost.

What do we know of ancient Nanumean religion and belief? Since Nanumea and Tuvalu are part of the larger Polynesian culture area, we know that our ancestors shared with other Polynesians the worship of such pan-Pacific gods as Tangaloa. This

tapuaki ki atua o te Pasefika kâtoa pelâ mo Tagaloa. Ko ia tenei, pelâ hoki mo Maumau, Folaha, Māgai, Laukite, Te Feke mo Te Lahi, e kau i loto o igoa o atua ni fakamaugina e tino faima'laga ki Nanumea i pō mua. E iloa e tātou me e i ai ni mo mea tapu ia me ni fale tapuaki mō atua takitokotahi konei (e i ai hoki he lipōti me ia Maumau e lua a ona fale tapuaki). A fale tapu konei e āti ki lau puga ki te mauluga e 9 futu ka e 2-6 futu a te lauefa.

E iloa e tatou me e i ai ni tino mo olotou iloa fakamailogagina kolā e mafai e lātou o takitaki a faigā tapuakiga mua. A lātou konei ni fāfine ia me ni tāgata, ka e fakaigoa ki "Vaka Atua." E mafai a lātou konei o fehokotaki ki olotou atua kae fai meālofa ki ai, a meālofa e kau i ai a te mea tafahili i te tāua i te olaga o tatou telā ko te niu. A gatipihō o tino takutakua mua e tausi faka'lei kae fakaaogā i taimi o tapuakiga a lātou. Kae ko te gatipihō o Tefolaha e tausi kae fakaaogā i taimi o fakafiafiaga faka te lotu.

E iloa hoki e tātou me ia Nanumea (mo tona falepili ko Nanumaga) e i ai he faifaiga takutakua faka te lotu telā ni fakatoka mō puipui a te fenua mai mea ma'hei, pelā hoki mo mahaki e mafai o aumai e tino faka'tea ki te fenua. A te faifaiga tenei e fai i matakatoga i te feitu ki te moana ka e pili ki te fa'kai. E manakogina ko tino 'fou konei ki uta i te fenua ke 'noho ailoa i te matāfaga oneonea ki he pō kâtoa, kae i te taimi nei a pehe, fakanau faka te lotu, mo fātele e fai mō faka'ma a tino 'fou konei.

He ā nei a te iloa o tātou i pō nei, e uiga mō te talitonuga o tino Nanumea mua e uiga ki te kāmataga o te lalolagi, pelā hoki mo te faitega o tino, manu mo mea ake hoki? E fakautu me atu lā e foliki 'ki. A te talitonuga ki te mata a muna tenei e kau i loto a te tokoukega o tino mua i fenua o te Pasefika, e pelā hoki mo fenua o te Polenisia, e fai pelā me i te fakavaeakega o te lalolagi e pōuli ka e haitia.

E iloa e tātou me i Nanumea e i ai he ana talitonuga mua e uiga ki te faitega o te lalolagi telā ko te apaiga o te lagi? E! e i ai ni tala toe'toe e mafai o fakapoopo atu i konei. A te tala muamua ni talagina e Taulialia kae ni puke e Kiti mo Ane i Nanumea i te 1974:

A te mea nei he tala i pō mua, mai taimi o te pōuliga, ki te 'vaega o te lalolagi mo te lagi. Aitu katoa o te lalolagi, feao pelā mo Maumau, Laukite, Naleau, Nakā, Aulialia, mo Tapualiki, ni 'luku fakatahi kae ni taumafai o 'vae a te laukele mo te lagi. Ni

name, and those of Maumau, Folaha, Maangai, Laukite, Te Feke and Te Lahi, were among the names of gods recorded by early visitors to Nanumea. We know that there were shrines or temples for each of these major gods (in one report Maumau was said to have two temples), that these shrines sometimes took the form of very large upright coral slabs, up to 9 feet high and from 2 to 6 feet wide.

We also know that we had people with special knowledge and abilities who led ritual activities. These people, who seem to have been women as well as men, may have been called Vakaatua, "vessels of the gods." They communicated with the gods and made offerings to them, offerings which included the all-important staff of life, the coconut. The skulls of important ancestors were preserved and used in religious rites too. Tefolaha's own skull was preserved and was used in religious ceremonies.

We also know that Nanumea (and neighboring Nanumaga) had a unique religious practice which was apparently designed to protect the island from evil influences and diseases brought by outsiders. These rituals probably had a name, but if so, it has been forgotten today. The rites took place at the ocean beach near the village. Foreigners were required to remain on the sandy shore for up to a whole day while songs, chants and dances were performed to cleanse them.

What do we know today of ancient Nanumean beliefs about the origin of the world and the creation of people, animals and other things? Sadly, only a little. The belief shared among many ancient Pacific island societies, and especially those in Polynesia, was that the world was originally a dark and very cramped place. The world as we now know it originated when one or more of the gods separated the earth and the heavens by lifting up the heavens, letting in light and allowing more space.

Did Nanumea have a traditional belief about the creation of the world by raising the sky? Yes, we did, and we include here several fragmentary versions. This first story was told by Taulialia and recorded by Keith and Anne Chambers at Nanumea in 1974:

This is a story of ancient times, from the "dark ages," about the separation of the earth and the sky. All of the aitua of the world, spirits such as Maumau, Laukite, Naleau, Nakaa, Taulialia, and Tapualiki gathered to try to separate the earth and the

fakaholo takitokotahi a lātou konei o apai a te lagi ki luga, ka e hē ni oko tonu ki te mauluga telā e manakogina, telā koa toe tukuifo ki lalo. Kae i te hauga a Māgāi, apai ake e ia kae kalaga ki aitu ake penei, "E ā i konei?" Kae tali atu a lātou, "Ki luga ake mālie!" Koa toe apai ake ke oko ailoa ki mō mea kolā e 'tau o tuku i ai. I pō nei a te lagi koa tū ailoa i te tūga tonu me ko Māgāi ni apai e ia. A olotou muna me ia te ia ko te aitu (atua) loa ailoa.

I te tonuga ailoa a te lagi mo te lalolagi e pa'tele fakatahi. A te ika ko te Ali ni taumafai o apai a te lagi. Kae ni pakū 'tao i a e te lagi, palapala i ai a tona foitino, tenā ne pāpā i ai a te ika tenei ko te Ali. Hau i ai a te puhi o fakahao a te ali, kae apai e ia a te lagi ki te mauluga telā ko ia tonu ailoa. A te puhi ko ia tenei ko Te Kaniva (te Milky Way), telā koa moe fakaloaloa i luga i te lagi.

A tala Nanumea konei e hē katoatoa, kae koa hē ai he faiga e mafai o fai ki ai. E hē iloa e tātou pelā me i 'tou tino Nanumea mua e tali'tonu me ni faite ailoa penei mai te taimi ni apai ake i ai a te lagi, ia me ko te Tuvalu kātoa ni fai hoki pēnā, ia me ko te tala tenei ko te tala i te faitega o te lalolagi katoa.

Te Lalolagi mai lalo i te Tai

I tafa o te lalolagi i luga (a te papa mo te lagi) a o'tou tino mua e tali'tonu hoki me e i ai he lalolagi mai lalo o te tai, telā e nohogina e tino kolā e pule i ai. A Hina mo Pākeva ko pule konei, ko atua o te tai, kae fai e 'moe a lāua, e fakaaogā a te ika ko te atu mō fai a lā uluga, ka e tuku a o lā vae i luga o te magō.

Ko te tala e tahi: Ia Hina mo Pākeva mo te i ai o te lalolagi mai lalo o te tai, e kau i ai a te tagata fāika Nanumea ko Hinoki ni fano ki te lalolagi tenei o 'hala a tana pā ni galo. Kae tahi hoki: Ko Kautuaia telā ni 'kave e Pākeva ki tana lalolagi mai lalo i te tai, he fakapulaga e ona me ko tō uke ana atu ni 'mate tele; telā ko te ika fakapelepele a Hina. A Kautuaia ni hao mai te luani o ika fo'liki.

E i ai he tamaliki tagata koa tai lahi 14-15 tauhaga; a tona igoa ko Tikitiki. Ko ia ailoa koa tupu māhei a tona foitino, vae homoa, kae matāpakua a tona foitino, kae kaupakapaka hoki. A tana mea e fai i te ukega o taimi, ko te kini kāpa ailoa i matakatoga.

sky. One by one each tried to shoulder the sky up but each one failed to reach high enough, and sat down. Finally came Māgai, the rainbow. He lifted, calling out to the other spirits: "how is it, spirits?" Several times they told him to lift "a little bit more" and he kept lifting. He lifted it into place and left it. And so today the sky is up there in place, because Māgai lifted it. They say he is the very tallest of the spirits (or ancestral gods).

Originally the sky and the earth were touching. The ali fish tried to lift up the sky. The sky crashed down on him, and this is why the ali has a flat body today. The eel came along to help the ali, and lifted the sky right up to its proper position. Today one can see the eel stretching across the sky as Te Kaniva, The Milky Way.

These Nanumean stories are incomplete, and we do not have much else to go on besides this. We do not know, for instance, if our Nanumean ancestors believed that Nanumea itself was formed this way when the sky was raised, or if all of Tuvalu was, or if this was a story about the creation of the whole world.

The Undersea World

Besides the world above (both the earth and the sky), our ancestors believed in an undersea world which was populated by beings who ruled there. Hina and Pākeva are the rulers, the gods, of the sea. When they sleep they use the atu for their pillows. They rest their legs on the shark. As a result, the flesh of sharks smells like urine, because Hina and Pākeva urinate during their sleep. By contrast, the flesh of the atu is the most desired of all.

In another story: A Nanumean fisherman, Hinoki, travels to the undersea world of Hina and Pākeva to seek his lost pā. And: Pākeva comes ashore in a blood-red wave. He takes Kautuaia to his undersea world as punishment for catching too many atu, Hina's favorite fish. Kautuaia escapes with the aid of some small fish.

This story is about a boy, Tikitiki, who was about 14 or 15 years old. He was really bad looking, skinny, with swollen legs and sores all over his body. His favorite pastime was to sit on the beach and drum on his kapa, biscuit tin drum. People would tell him

Kae fai atu a tino ke lava i te mea koa 'mae a taliga, e hē fia fakalogo a ia nei. O'mai a tino konei, puke a ia nei, 'fao ki loto i te gatipūpū mo ana kautā konei e lua, kae 'ti ki te tai. E hē leva a te tapeapeaga i te tai(moana) kae i luga a te tafolā oti ni folo e ia a te gatipūpū tenei.

Te Tagata ko Tefolaha

Pelā mo te iloa e tātou i pō nei manafai e ta'vili a tatou ki te kamataga o Nanumea, a tātou e pelā me hē mafau'fau ki te apaiga o te lagi, me ko atua mua pelā mo Tangaroa, Maumau, Telahi mo Pakeva, kae mafau'fau ki a Pai mo Vau i te lā hepakiga fakapoi mo te tagata mahala e igoa ki a Tefolaha. Me ni pēhea a te iloa e tātou me ko Tefolaha ni maua e ia Nanumea, kae e hē iloa tonu a te taimi ni oko mai i ai a ia ki Nanumea.

Ka fai e fakaaogā e tātou a te 25 tauhaga i te kautama (tāgata takitokotahi ko te 25 tauhaga a te matua manafai koa fanau a tana tama ki mua). E fakatautau pelā me i te tagata tenei ko Tefolaha (kae faka Samoa ko Folasa-aitu, kae faka Kilipai ko Teborata) ni ola mai i loto i te vāhia o te 1250 mo te 1350 A.D. E tāua ke manatua e tātou me hē he taimi e iloa tonu tenei; a te taimi tonu e mafai o heke 'mao 'ki mo te fakatautauga tenei.

"E Oku a te Fenua Nei!"

Mai luga o tala tuku fakaholo o te fenua, ni iloa ake i ai me i te fenua tenei ko Nanumea, ni faite e te tokolua fāfine aitu e igoa ki a Pai mo Vau. Ni lēle mai i luga i te ea, e 'noho i luga i te loulou mo te lā kete one, telā ni 'ligi i mō mea o te moana konā ni oko ki ai, tupu ake ailoa i ai a te fenua.

A Tefolaha, he tahi o toa takutakua mai te fenua tenei ko Tonga. E i ai he ona feitū aitu, ka e i ai hoki he ona feitū tino. Ni ola i te vaitaimi ni fai taua tele i ai a fenua o te Pasefika, e pelā mo fenua konei ko Tonga, Samoa mo Fiji. I ona taimi faimalaga, ni oko atu i ai a ia ki te atu fenua ko Tuvalu, kae ni oko atu a ia ki te fenua tēnei ko Nanumea. Ni lavea e ia a te gali o te fenua, fia fai ailoa i ai a ia ke fai mō fai tona fenua.

Kae tukutuku ifo e ia a te leti ki luga tonu ailoa i te piho o te fāfine e tokotahi, telā ni kalaga ake i ai a tona tauhoa i ona tafa pēnei: "E Pai! e i ai he mea tenā koa tai 'paki ki tou piho!" Kae koa 'futi ake e Tefolaha a te leti ki luga. Toe fai hoki e ia pēna ki luga o te piho o te fāfine ake, kae kalaga ake a Pai penei: "E Vau! E tenā hoki koa fanaifo, koa tai patele

to stop, because it was hurting their ears, but he would not listen. One day a person came along, grabbed Tikitiki, stuffed him and his two drumsticks into an empty coconut shell, and threw him into the sea. He had not drifted far out to sea when a whale came along and swallowed the coconut shell.

The Man Called Tefolaha

As we all know, today when we talk about the beginnings of Nanumea, we do not usually think of raising the sky, or of our ancient gods such as Tangaloa, Maumau, Te Lahi or Pākeva, but of two women named Pai and Vau and their encounter with a very clever man by the name of Tefolaha. While we all know that Tefolaha is the founder of the island of Nanumea, we are not sure exactly when he may have come to Nanumea.

If we use a number of about 25 years per generation (each male is about 25 years old when his first child is born), then one can estimate that Tefolaha (or as he was called in Samoa, Folasa-aitu, or in Kiribati, Teborata), lived sometime in the period 1250 to about 1350 A.D. It is important for us to remember that this is only a rough estimate, and the actual date could be far different than this.

"This Island is Mine!"

Nanumean traditional tales tell us that Nanumea was created by two women named Pai and Vau. They flew through the air with their loulou picking stick and their kete basket of sand, which spilled out at each place they came to, and from which grew an island.

Tefolaha was a famous warrior from Tonga. He had a spirit [aitu] side as well as a human side. He lived at the time when the various Pacific island countries were at war, especially the islands of Tonga, Samoa and Fiji. In his travels, Tefolaha reached the Tuvalu archipelago, and came here to the island of Nanumea. He noticed the beauty of the island and wanted it for his own.

He let down a tiny leti right over the head of the first woman, who cried out to her friend at her side: "Hey Pai! There is something that is about to touch your head!" So Tefolaha pulled the leti up again. He did this again over the head of the other woman, and Pai cried out: "Hey Vau! There it is again coming down, and just about touching your head!" Tefolaha

ake ailoa ki tou piho!" Tiakina atu e Tefolaha te leti, kae makini ifo ki lalo a 'tou tagata, fakaliu tino ake, kae mafuli mai ki ou fāfine konei, mo ana muna ailoa penei: "Atu lā, e 'tau ailoa o fai he faiga me ko ai e ona a te fenua tenei."

Ni tali atu a Tefolaha penei, "Ake, kae fai e iloa e koulua me ko ai a toku igoa, koa talitonu aku, me o koulua ailoa a te fenua." A te tokolua fāfine konei, koa oko ailoa i te mata fakautu, kae koa fai ake ailoa o 'tagi, mo a lā muna ailoa penei, "Ikai, e hē iloa e māua a tou igoa." Ni pula'tonu atu a mata o Tefolaha kae fai atu penei, "A tou igoa ko Pai, ka ko koe ko Vau. Atu lā koa 'tau ailoa mo koulua o loto ma'lie pelā mo te mea ni iku ia tatou; kae ke gā fakatoka lā a oulua kope kae oloatu kiatea mai toku fenua." Ni olo a te tokolua fāfine konei a Pai mo Vau, mai te alā fenua tonu mo te fakautu lahi.

A tala faka Nanumea ake e uiga kia Pai mo Vau, fai mai me ni tiaki e lāua a Nanumea mo te 'tagi, kae hoho a te lā loulou i olā tua, telā ni mafai ai o mafāfā a te kaupapa o te fenua i te muli o te loulou. E i ai ni one ni mā'ligi mai te alā kete telā ni māfua ake i ai a motu tai fo'liki i loto i te namo o Nanumea. A Pai mo Vau ni olo faka-mātū ki fenua o Kilipati. I fenua o Tokelau, a mō muna konei "fāfine hauai," a tona uiga "ni fāfine fakamatakua." A Tokelau mo Tuvalu e 'tai 'pau ailoa alā 'gana mo alā faifaiga.

Te Tupumaiga o Tāgata Nanumea

I te ologa a Pai mo Vau, kae koa pule nei a Tefolaha ia Nanumea. Kae ko ai a Laukite? E i ai ni toeaina Nanumea ni fai'tala mātou fai mai me i te fāfine tenei he aitu ia me he feao. Ka e pelā mo te mea ni lavea e tātou mai te kamataga o te Matāupu tenei, a Laukite e iloa tonu me he atua hoki e tokotahi ni tapuaki ki ai a 'otou tino mua; a ia he atua. E i ai hoki he tala koa iloa tonu e faka'hoko ki te tala nei, fai mai me ia Tefolaha mo Laukite e tokolima a lā tama'liki kae ni fāfine katoa. A olotou igoa ko Koli, Finehau, Nenefu, Lei mo Moega. Fai mai a te tala, e tokofā mai a lātou konei, e tau anuanu e pelā me ni manu ka e 'kai tino hoki. Telā lā ni 'ta katoa a lātou konei. Kae mai te tokolima o alā tama konei, ko Koli ailoa ni fakahao, me e anuanu ailoa pelā me he tino, kae nā ko tona gutu ake, e tai 'pau mo te gutu o te ika ko te pāla.

E i ai hoki ni tala ake ki te tupumaiga o tino Nanumea mai a Tefolaha, telā koa kau i ai a te tinā fāfine tonu (ola) e igoa ki a Puleala, ko te mātua o tamaliki a Tefolaha. I te tala hoki e tahi a kau i ai a Puleala: I te ologa a Pai mo Vau, a Tefolaha ni toe

tossed away the leti and went quickly down from the attic. He said: "Maybe we should do something to decide whose this island really is?"

"Look, if you two know my name, I'll believe that this island is really yours. And I'll just leave your island then. But if I am able to guess your names, then you should be the ones to leave the island." The two women were crestfallen and started to cry, and said, "No, we do not know your name." Tefolaha stared right at them and said, "Your name is Pai, and you are Vau. So probably you two should just go ahead and do what we agreed, and get your things ready and leave my island." The two women, Pai and Vau, left with great sadness.

Some Nanumean stories tell us that Pai and Vau left Nanumea in tears, dragging their picking stick (loulou) behind them. As they went, the stick cut a groove in the reef flat of Nanumea, something which can still be seen there on the eastern ocean reef. Sand spilled from their baskets and formed the smaller islets in Nanumea's lagoon. Pai and Vau went on north toward the Gilbert Islands. In the Tokelau Islands, the phrase fāfine hauai means female ogres, supernatural women who may eat human flesh. Tokelau and Tuvalu are very similar in language and culture.

The Origin of the Nanumeans

Once Pai and Vau left, Tefolaha had possession of Nanumea. Who was Laukite? While some of the Nanumean elders we consulted say this woman was an aitu or feao, a ghost or spirit, we have seen at the start of this chapter that Laukite is also named as one of the major gods our ancestors worshiped. It is important to remember that when the earliest outside visitors came to Nanumea, they were also told that Te Folaha was one of Nanumea's gods. One well-known version of this story says that Tefolaha and Laukite had five children, all of them girls. Their names were Koli, Finehau, Nenefu, Lei and Moega. The story says that four of the girls had faces like an animal, and they were cannibalistic too. So, all of them were killed. Out of the five children, only Koli was spared.

There are other versions of how Nanumeans descend from Tefolaha, however, which involve a fully human woman named Puleala as the mother of Tefolaha's children. After Pai and Vau left, Tefolaha returned to Tonga and there he married Puleala

foki ki Tonga, kae ni toe avaga ki a Puleala (a tona igoa e tahi ko Tauaho). E hē leva, koa toe fia fano hoki a Tefolaha o toe foki ki Nanumea, kae ni olo tahi mo tana āvaga, mo te tuagane o tana āvaga ko Te'tea, fakatahi mo kāiga o lāua. I te okoatuga tenei a Tefolaha mo tana āvaga i te tokolua tenei ko Puleala ni fai i ai a lā tama tāgata konei e tokotolu; konei a olotou igoa ko Tutaki, Fiaola mo Lavega.

Te Fenua mo tona Fakatulagaga

A Nanumea, he fenua e tahi mai fenua e valu o te Atu Fenua ko Tuvalu telā e kau i loto i fenua o te vasa Pasefika ki Saute, i te lanu telā ko te Polenisia. Ko ia e tautafa ki Mātū o te atu fenua, ka e tai pilipili ki Kilipati. A tona tulaga i te mape ko te 5.39 degree S. Latitude, mo te 176.08 degree E. Longitude. A tona lahi kātoa telā e kau i ai a te kaupapa fakatāmilo ki ai a te fenua e 13km me 8.2 maila, kae 2.7 km te lauefa. Kae ko te lahi o tona laukele, telā e kau i ai a ona motu, Lakena, Temotufoliki, Lafogaki mo Te Āfua a Taepoa e 3.8 km.sq me 1.46 miles.

Kae koi tuai o oko mai a 'palagi, e hēai he ava lahi mai moana ki loto i te namo o Nanumea. Atu lā ko te 1930 i te taimi o te faigā mālō faka kolone, mai lalo o te pulepulega a Donald Kennedy, ni paula i ai he ava i te kaupapa mai tai tonu ailoa o te fa'kai. A te ava tenei e fakaigoa ko te "ava a Kennedy." Koa lahi a te fakaogā o te ava tenei i taimi o vakamutu mai Funafuti. E pelā hoki mo vaka fai lā foliki (yachts) e mafai hoki o olo ki loto i te namo, o fakamanava io me o faka'lafi i taimi o kaumatagi.

A te tau o te aho o te fenua, e lava ki te 'lei i loto i te tauhaga kātoa. A te Tokelau (Trade Wind) e tūmau a tona agiagi mālie mai te fanakega o te lā, kae tumau hoki ailoa a te 'to o ua i vā o taimi. Vāganā i ai ko mahina fakaotioti o te tauhaga o fano ki mahina ki mua o te tauhaga fou; ko taimi konei o kau matagi 'lahi i loto katoa o te atu fenua o Tuvalu.

I te vāhia o te 1950-70, a te tokouke o tino Nanumea i luga ailoa o te fenua, e noho tele ailoa mai luga o te afe. Kae i te 1970 o hau ailoa ki te 2000, koa faigatā o oko ki te afe a tino i luga i Nanumea. Mai te laugā tino o te 2002, a te aofaki o tino Nanumea ni pakū ki lalo ki te 669, me i te tauhaga 2012 e i ai 544 tino i luga te fenua ko Nanumea mo i te 2022, 610 tino. Telā lā e i ai he tuku fakatautau pelā me i tino Nanumea katoa, koa mafai o hiliga atu mo te lua afe a te aofaki.

(whose other name was Tauaho), a real person. Before long, Tefolaha wanted to return to Nanumea. He left with his wife, the brother of his wife named Tetea, together with family members of these two. On this voyage with his second wife, three boy children were born to her and Tefolaha. Their names were Tutaki, Fiaola and Lavega.

The Island and Its Location

Nanumea stands alone as one of the nine islands of Tuvalu, all located in the central-south Pacific in the cultural region known as Polynesia. Nanumea is the northernmost of the Tuvalu islands, and is thus close to Kiribati. Its location on the map is at 5.39 degrees south latitude, 176.08 degrees east longitude. The island including its sand beaches is about 13km or 8.2 miles long, by 2.7 km or 1.6 miles wide. Its land area, including Nanumea proper and the islets of Lakena, Te Motu Foliki, Lafogaki and Teafua-a-Taepoa is 3.8 sq. km., or 1.46 sq. miles.

Before Europeans came, there were no large passes into the Nanumean lagoon from the sea. In about 1930, the British Colonial administration, under the supervision of Donald Kennedy, blasted a pass in the coral reef right in front of the village. This pass, "Kennedy's Pass," was used for ten or fifteen years before the Americans came to Nanumea during World War II. They blasted a new and deeper pass, from the ocean right through into the lagoon. This "American Pass," as it is called, is about 20 meters wide by 200 meters in length. Its main use is when cargo ships come from Funafuti.

The island's weather is normally good throughout the year. The Trade Wind is generally steady from the east, and rain falls at regular intervals. Nevertheless, there are months at the end of the year and into the start of the new year in which there are fierce storms throughout all of Tuvalu. The winds shift to the west and may reach a velocity of 50-60 miles per hour, with considerable damage to the island's houses and vegetation.

In the 1950s through the 1970s, the number of people resident on Nanumea was more than a thousand. But starting in the late 1970's and continuing on to the 21st century, the island's resident population has steadily declined. According to the 2002 census, Nanumea's population had dropped to 669. The 2012 census showed only 544 people living on Nanumea; in 2022, the census recorded a slight increase to 610 residents. We

Te Motu ko Lakena

A te motu ko Lakena e hili mālie ailoa mai luga i te afa o Nanumea ake ailoa; kae ko te lahi o te laukele e 119 hectares (294 acres). Ko te motu tenei e 'tu katoa i ai a talo a te fenua. I lalo i talo, e 'toki i ai a pulaka mo fakatafa talo. I pō mua, i loto i pō o te pōtapu, e pule ailoa a te tino i te taimi e fano i ia a ia o gālue i ana talo i Lakena. Kae ko te pōlima, he pō ailoa e iloa tonu, me i te tokoukega o pule o kāiga e olo ailoa ki Lakena o 'ta pulaka mō 'kai a te kāiga i te pō ono mo te pō tapu.

E i ai he vai e igoa ko Te Koko, e tū tonu i te gāloto o te fenua, ka e tai pili ki fale i te fa'kai. E mahani o fakamānava i ai a toeaina mo olotou kete pulaka, o 'puhi ia me o kau'kau i te koko i te olotou auala mai vao o 'foki ki fale. I pō mua, ni vaka ailoa e fakaogā mō olo tele ki Lakena ia me ki te feitū ki matagi o te fenua. E manuia a vaka kolā e olo ki Lakena, kae tūgamālie a te matagi, me e mafai o hihi a lā a olotou vaka.

Ka e pehea nei a te tulaga o te fano ki Lakena i pō nei? Koa tafaga hoki la a te foe a te 'palagi i te hē gauia, koa mafai e pasese o te pikilua (i pō nei, pooti fai galuega), puke he pelē mo ta'hao i luga i te pikilua i tona auala ki Lakena, koa mafai hoki o puke ni pasika ta ki vae, mo lava tala e tuku i loto i taga palasitiki. E māfai o molimau, kae fakamaonigina e tātou a te lahi o te mafuliga o pō nei, faka'pau ki te 30-40 tauhaga koa olo atu.

Iloga o te Fenua

A Nanumea e uke 'ki a ona iloga telā e fakatino ki ai a tona mailoga, ka e i ai hoki ailoa ni tala mua e fakavae ki ai. A te lakau tau e fakaogā mō taua, telā lā ko "Te Kaumaile" e fakamuna e te tokoukega o tino Nanumea me ko te ki e fakatino ki ai a te o'tou iloga. E tali'tonu a tātou, mē ni aumai ki Nanumea e Tefolaha, kae ni 'kave ki tana tama ko Tutaki, kae fakamuli ifo ni fakaogā e Lapi telā ni hau i te gafa o Tutaki mō tā a te tagata lahi kae fakamataku e igoa ki a Tūlāpoupou.

He hōkoga hoki e tahi mai tala mua telā e luani ki te pulaga a tino Nanumea ki ona iloga fakamātea, ko te faigāmuna penei, "Tefolaha tou hoa!" Ko muna konei a Lapi ni fakaogā i te taimi ni kalaga i ai a ia kia Tefolaha ke luani ki a te ia i te tāga o te tagata lahi fakamataku tenei e igoa ki a Tūlāpoupou. I pō

would estimate that, taken all together, the number of Nanumeans today is certainly over 2,000.

The Islet of Lakena

The islet of Lakena is just over half the size of Nanumea itself, with 119 hectares (294 acres) of land. It is on this islet that all the taro pits of Nanumea are located. In these pits both pulaka and taro are planted. In the old days, within any week, it was up to the individual when he or she went to work in their taro pits in Lakena. Today, Friday has been selected as the special day in which the majority of family heads go to Lakena to harvest pulaka for use on Saturday and Sunday.

Right in the midst of Lakena, close to the village, is a freshwater lake known as Te Koko. People often rest here after working in their gardens. In days past, canoes were the only way to get back and forth to Lakena or across the lagoon to the Matagi side of the island. Canoes going to Lakena are usually favored by the wind, and could just put up their sails and sail downwind.

But look at the situation today. In going to Lakena, we rely on the easy "paddle" of the Europeans. Passengers on the island's work transport boat can take their cards and play games on the way to Lakena, taking along their bicycles and a change of clothes in a plastic bag. We can see the huge changes that have happened in the past 30 to 40 years.

Symbols of the Community's Identity

As a community, Nanumea has a range of markers which identify it as unique. The fighting spear known as Te Kaumaile is widely considered by Nanumeans to be a key symbol of Nanumean identity. Believed to have been brought to Nanumea by Tefolaha, passed to his son Tutaki, and later used by Tutaki's descendant Lapi to defeat the giant Tulapoupou, today (2026) it is cared for by the Pulefenua and island leaders.

Another historical connection which helps Nanumeans focus their identity is the phrase, "Tefolaha tou hoa!" referring to the words Lapi used when he called on Tefolaha to help him defeat Tulapoupou. Today, one often sees this phrase on shirts and other clothing. Many people say that

nei koa mafai o lavea e tātou a te faigāmuna tenei i luga i lava mo hulu.

E tokouke a tino e fai pelā me i tino Nanumea e hili atu a te ma'nako o lātou o 'kai niu, i lo tino ake o Tuvalu. Pēla mo te iloa e tātou a Pai mo Vau mai luga, ni lavea i ai e tātou me ni lēia i te fakataufaiga mo Tefolaha. E tau ke iloa e tātou a igoa kolā e fakaigoa tele ki ai a putukau ta'hao e lua manafai e 'vae, ko Pai mo Vau. A Nanumea e iloa tonu i te 'gali o ana mea kolā e faite ki lima, kolā a fenua ake koa taumafai nei o fakākoako ki ai.

Nanumeans like to eat coconut more than some other Tuvaluans. We also know that our favorite names for two teams, whenever we divide up to play a game, are Pai and Vau. Nanumea is well known for the quality and distinctive nature of many handmade items.